

How Video Game Content is Driving Adult Animation's Expansion into Mainstream

A look at how the videogame industry is merging with mainstream entertainment, and how game CGI has become a major force in the advancement of animation aimed at wider audiences.

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1 INTRODUCTION

Balson, Aitken, Bottegoni, Zampas, Rabb, Ward and Suwalski comprise the top minds in the world of video game narrative content and entertainment, having been part of some of the most critically applauded work in recent years. In this talk, they will discuss the giant strides we have seen within game IPs and that video game narrative content has taken in reaching new audiences and becoming a mainstream form of entertainment.

The talk will commence with an overview of highlights of the 2018 presentation “THE PAST, PRESENT AND FUTURE OF THE GAME CINEMATIC”, the panellists will discuss their journey in the context of their own body of work and the studios at which they work, looking at how their work has developed and how the format has evolved to meet the changing needs of their clients.

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2 WHERE WE ARE TODAY

2.1 The tools, technology and processes

The video game cinematic is a genre unto itself, blending traditional video games with the innovative storytelling of animated shorts. Panelists will dive into what comprises the ‘look’ that has emerged in their work for video games – highly rendered, cinematically filmed, complex, fantastic characters rendered with incredible detail and expressed through intense performances. The panel will discuss and debate the origins and progression of this aesthetic and the various factors that led to the characteristics we see in narrative Game content today.

2.2 Beyond the games industry

For years, high-fidelity, high-quality animation was only affordable to large triple-A game makers and aimed at increasingly mature players, relegating the artform's reach to a robust but relatively small audience. Over time, higher-quality animation, both pre-rendered and engine-rendered, has proliferated and become noticed by non-gamers. During the last few years especially, as game IP has become a new picking-ground for mainstream entertainment, adult-aimed animation can be found in series like Riot Games' “Arcane” on Netflix, and the animated anthology series “Love, Death & Robots.”

As technology is constantly evolving and the younger audience is becoming more accepting of new digital experiences, we are seeing a progression of the conversion of video game fandom into wider entertainment media. Panelists will discuss the innovation in the genre and how its unique characteristics are being used to further explore what is possible in animation.

3 GOING MAINSTREAM

3.1 Gaming is now mainstream and the fastest growing entertainment sector

In recent years, video games have taken animation to a different audience, with the quality of CGI cinematics and trailers thrilling

their adult viewers. From stylized to increasingly photoreal output, computer games have outgrown the domain of geeks and gamers and moved into the mainstream, with many game IPs becoming entertainment brands with movies and TV series spawning from their origins. In this section, panelists take a closer look at the reasons the genre has taken this direction, how have they got to where they are and why?

3.2 Adult Animation

The beauty of animation is that it has no style, no rules, and no need to conform. It can be anything. It's art. Moving art - literally. It can tell any story, to any audience. Possibilities are endless and so far, we've only just started the exploration.

Animation has limitless possibilities, and it transcends time and context. 60-year-old Disney movies can still charm today's audiences. Animation can also deal with big themes and 'difficult' content in ways that live action can't. Although animation has unlimited parameters for storytelling and creating looks and aesthetics, in theory, most animation is aimed at kids knowing what the audience will like in a tried and tested formula.

For some time, animators, artists and studios have known that we're barely scratching the surface of all that animation has to offer. Adult-themed animation has been poised to surface the mainstream for some time and it's now imminent. A combination of audience interest and technical development has aligned to give potential to a new breed of animation that can take many forms. Are studios such as those represented by the panel uniquely positioned to take advantage of the shift of attitudes towards Animation as a medium?

3.3 The impact of streamers: Creating new partnerships

One of the big contributors to the convergence of Video Games content and mainstream entertainment is the rise of the streamers. The symbiotic relationship between streaming platforms, games and esports revolutionized how we consume and create content and allowed for a new type of storytelling. The panelists will delve into the creations and collaborations that have been born from this latest synergy and interesting ways in which game collaborators might come together in the future.

4 FUTURE

4.1 The real-time revolution & technological innovations

The panel will sidestep into the increasing use of next-generation game engines and real-time game technologies to create linear stories and cinematics. They will also look at how we are employing cutting-edge technology to achieve the flexibility to focus on the story, which is propelling story-driven content creation.

4.2 What's still to come

The panel will discuss what they foresee for the future of games and adult animation outside the realm of a video game. This discussion will be accompanied by reference to real examples of work that demonstrates this trend including recent and ongoing projects for broadcast and streaming giants, that have perhaps been deemed commercially too risky previously. The panel will reveal what they see for the future of adult animation if the market is ready for it.